

A study 'shows' something in the news, and you take the headline as the whole finding

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

The exaggeration usually starts before the reporter does: when a headline says a study "**causes**" something, that word is often already in the press release. Headline writers sit furthest from the paper.

THE GOAL

You want to repeat what the study actually found. Open the article behind the headline before you pass anything on.

CHECKLIST

the moment right before you repeat what a headline said, to someone else or online

- ☐ Open the article behind the headline before you repeat anything from it.
- ☐ Find the line that says who or what was studied: people, animals, cells, or a model.
- ☐ If it wasn't done in people, say "in animals" or "in a lab" when you repeat it.
- ☐ Find the sentence describing the result, and check whether it says the two things happened together or that one caused the other.
- ☐ If it only says they happened together, say "linked to" or "tied to," not "causes."
- ☐ Look further down the article for a line starting "however," "one limitation," or naming a small sample.
- ☐ If you find that line, carry its point with you when you repeat the finding; don't cut it to sound more certain.
- ☐ Check whether any "you should" advice in the headline is the thing the study measured, or an add-on.
- ☐ Drop any "you should" advice the study didn't actually test.
- ☐ Pick the one sentence you'll say or send: the finding, what it was tested on, and no certainty word beyond what the article gives you.
- ☐ Save the link before you send it on, so whoever you tell can check it themselves.
- ☐ If you learn later the claim didn't hold up, tell the same person or thread, not just yourself.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Repeating a headline you never finished reading makes you feel like you understood it. You don't actually know more than you did before, only **feel like you do**.
- 2 When a headline says a study "**causes**" something, that word is usually already sitting in the press release, not something a reporter added to sound more exciting.
- 3 The headline is usually written by someone other than the reporter whose name is on the story. That person is often the one **furthest** from the original press release.

Why this isn't really a character flaw

KNOW

Repeating a headline you never finished reading makes you feel like you understood it. You don't actually know more than you did before, only **feel like you do**.

People who shared an article without reading it still ended up feeling like they knew the topic, though they didn't. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Most people don't read everything they share. Only about a **quarter** say they read the whole thing, so skipping the rest puts you with most people, not a few.

In the same research, just 28% of people said they'd read every article they had ever shared with someone. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Don't drop an "early days" or "single study" caveat just to sound more sure. Newsrooms picked up hedged versions of a story **just as often** as confident ones.

In a trial testing this directly, honestly hedged versions of a story got picked up by news just as often as the confident ones. [Source 2](#)

Where the exaggeration in the story actually starts

KNOW

When a headline says a study "**causes**" something, that word is usually already sitting in the press release, not something a reporter added to sound more exciting.

Press officers often aren't hyping on purpose. Simpler wording just reads better than a hedge does. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

Watch for a study on animals, cells, or a model being described like it already works in people. **More than a third** of press releases make that same leap themselves.

Once a press release already blurred it, the resulting news repeated that blur most of the time, not just sometimes. [Source 4](#)

DON'T

Don't assume a headline's "you should do this" advice is exactly what the study tested. It's often stronger than that, and it usually starts at the press release, not the news story.

About **4 in 10** press releases already gave more direct advice than the paper itself supported. [Source 4](#)

What the wording itself is hiding

KNOW

The headline is usually written by someone other than the reporter whose name is on the story. That person is often the one **furthest** from the original press release.

Researchers who studied this coded headlines and article text separately, since a different person usually writes each one. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

The word "significant" in a study write-up doesn't tell you whether an effect is **big enough to matter**. It only means the result probably isn't exactly zero.

Journalists covering studies often assume "significant" means the effect is large or important, which the word alone doesn't tell you. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

A story running in a big, well-known outlet means a reporter checked it against the original study before publishing.

ACTUALLY

A news story's wording tracks its press release **far more closely** than it tracks the actual study it's about. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/misinformation-desk/202212/study-few-people-read-what-they-share>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6521363/>
3. <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0168217>
4. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4262123/>
5. <https://journalistsresource.org/home/statistical-significance-research-5-things/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Science in the headlines at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](https://cheatgrid.com)